A PROPOSAL FOR THE STOREFRONT AT

178 Lafayette Street

PJ O'Rourke II, the New York artist who started selling his prints off a hand-built cart on subway platforms, puts his flagship in a 705 square foot jewel box in the heart of SoHo and Nolita.



The window on Lafayette Street. Visualization from the measured model of the space.

705
SQUARE FEET, PLUS CELLAR

18'-2"
OF GLASS ON LAFAYETTE

6
TRAIN, FOUR MINUTES AWAY

THE SPACE

A white box with a black steel face

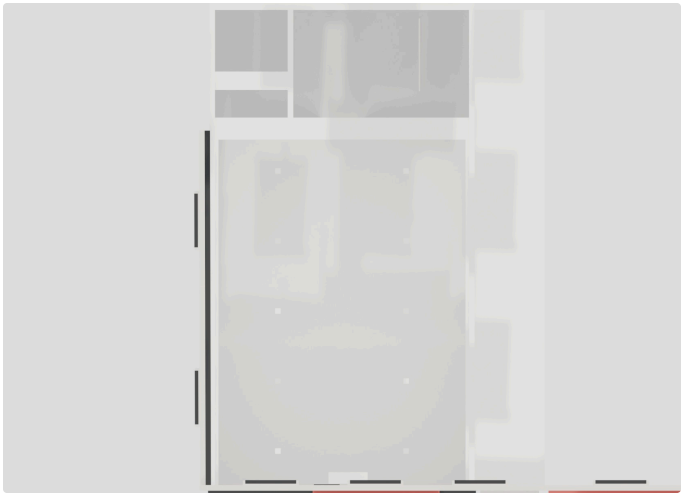
One clean room, 18 feet 2 inches wide and 25 feet deep, under a white pressed-tin ceiling with ten bare bulbs in two rows. Pale grey tile underfoot, white plaster walls, a split system over the door. Behind it, a bath and the stair down to a dedicated 13 by 41 foot cellar for stock.

The storefront is one run of heavy black steel: a display window, a pair of glass doors, a second display window, with louvred vents above and a plain black fascia ready for one name. Ownership delivers white box with HVAC.

Ground floor	705 rentable sq ft
Sales room	18'-2" x 25'-0"
Cellar	13'-11" x 41'-4", dedicated
Frontage	Two display windows and a centre door pair
Ceiling	Pressed tin, about 10'-6"
Delivery	White box, HVAC in place
Back of house	Bath and stair to cellar
Block	Lafayette between Grand and Broome



Looking to the street from the back of the room.



Plan of the fitted-out room, from the model.

SoHo meets Nolita

Lafayette is the seam between the cast-iron district and the little streets east of it. Foot traffic comes both ways: the SoHo shopper walking east, the Nolita local walking west.

On the 6

Spring Street and Canal Street on the 6 are each a four-minute walk. Canal Street's N, Q, R, W, J and Z are five. Prince Street's R and W are seven.

A landmarked front

The building is a 1906 walk-up inside the SoHo-Cast Iron Historic District Extension. The red fire escape and cream brick above the shop are the backdrop.

THE STORE

Prints on one wall, tees on the other, the figure in the window



Straight down the room from the door.

The gallery wall

The south wall is hung with PJ's prints in one level row of black frames: the line drawings of New York characters that started the whole thing on the subway platforms.

The shelving wall

The north wall is matte black pipe and white oak plank, planks of folded tees above and a rail of hangers below, one colourway to a bay: cream, navy, lilac, moss, peach.

The floor

Two white oak tables carry the folded stock and the current drop. A black counter sits by the back door. A Galaga cabinet stands in the back corner, because every PJ store has one.

The window

Gumbit, the bubblegum-pink suit-and-tie character, stands four feet tall on a black plinth in the north window, lit from above, facing Lafayette Street. The south window carries the signature in white and the newest work.



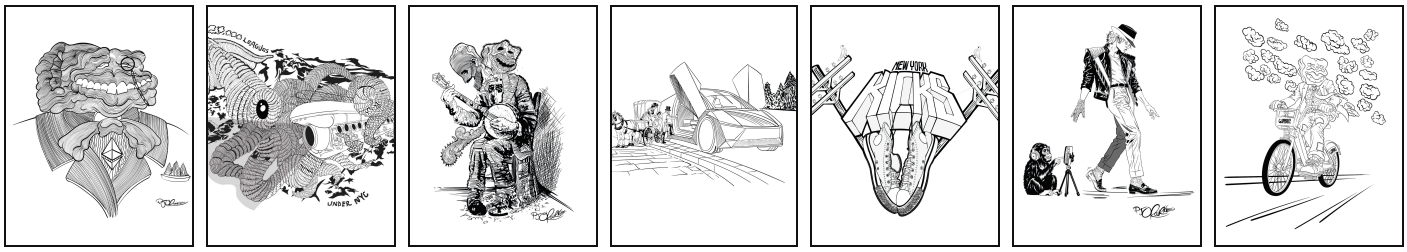
The print wall.



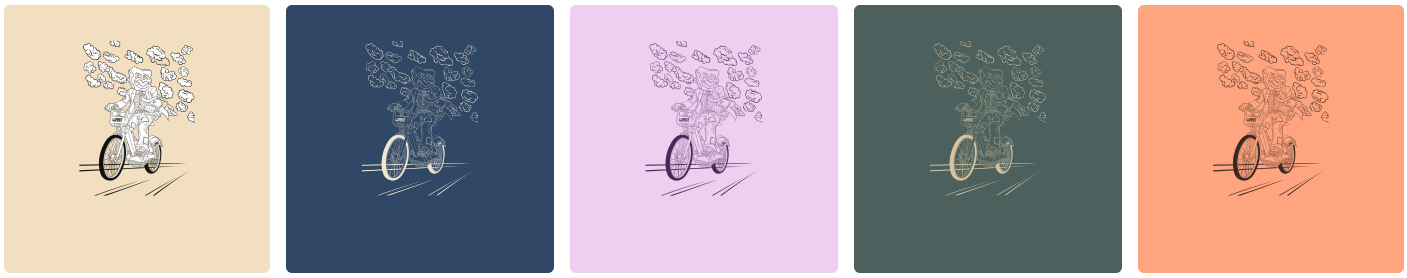
The shelving wall and the window.

THE WORK

Drawn by hand, printed in New York



Seven of the prints that hang on the gallery wall.



The five colourways of the heavyweight garment-dyed tee, 100% USA cotton, screen printed with the line work.

Graphic tees, crop tees, hoodies and bombers, art prints in two sizes, and the Gumbit figure as a small collectible edition. Kids sizes already in the line. Everything carries the signature.

THE BUSINESS

Fourteen years of selling directly to New York

On September 26, 2012, PJ O'Rourke II wheeled a hand-built art cart onto an MTA subway platform and started selling his prints to whoever walked past. No connections, no capital, no permission.

Born in Tulsa, he dropped out of college, landed on a friend's couch in Astoria with one month to figure it out, and built the cart from a single Home Depot trip, metal clips and chicken wire. The subway became his first gallery: raw, public and unforgiving. For eight years he sold directly to the public underground, refining the voice and building a following the hardest way possible.

In 2014 the pop-ups started in DUMBO, and the prints became apparel on a used heat press. In 2019 he opened his first storefront in the East Village, at 11th Street and First Avenue. The shop, the online store and the Instagram have run ever since.

85,800

FOLLOWERS ON INSTAGRAM, @PJOROURKEII

2012

FIRST SALE, ON A SUBWAY PLATFORM

2019

FIRST STOREFRONT, EAST VILLAGE

What the brand is

- New York lore, drawn by hand: the characters, the walk-ups, the hydrants, the platform edge.
- The platform-edge capsule, built on the yellow tactile strip every New Yorker knows underfoot.
- Gumbit, the character, going from the drawings to a figure.
- Pop-ups, drops and a store that people come to on purpose.



178 Lafayette Street from across the road.

WHY 178 LAFAYETTE

Small, bright, and on the right street

A 700 square foot flagship on a corridor that people already walk is the format PJ has proved for a decade: tight, curated, built for content and conversation, with the stock downstairs and the window doing the work.

The room needs almost nothing done to it. The tin ceiling, the tile and the white walls stay. The fit-out is freestanding: pipe-and-plank shelving, oak tables, frames on the wall. In and trading fast, out cleanly.

The window is the sign. A four-foot pink figure facing Lafayette Street, lit at night, with the signature in white on the glass beside it.



Along the sidewalk, from the north.

Hours

Seven days. Late on Thursday, Friday and Saturday, when Lafayette is busiest.

Events

Print releases, tee drops, artist nights. The room clears to a gallery in an hour.

Online

pjorourkeii.com and @pjorourkeii carry the store to the rest of the city and beyond.

CONTACT

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